
TRANSITIONS LAB · PRIMER

Reading a Transition

How to study a technology as it meets real people: a primer on socio-technical transitions, read from the human side first.

For innovators, funders, and researchers who want to understand why technically excellent technologies succeed or fail once they leave the lab.

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PRIMER

A technology is never just a technology

An artefact on its own tells you almost nothing about what it will do. The same device, dropped into two different contexts, produces two different outcomes. To predict either, you have to study the whole system, technology and people together.

This is the central insight of socio-technical thinking, and the foundation of everything the Lab does. A technology is an artefact plus the people who use it, the institutions that govern it, the incentives that surround it, and the place it lands in. Studied in isolation, it is illegible. Studied in context, it becomes possible to understand and, sometimes, to steer.

Technology is not destiny. A transition can be steered, toward people's values, or away from them. Reading it well is what makes steering possible.

READING A TRANSITION

WHAT A SOCIO-TECHNICAL SYSTEM IS

The unit of analysis is the interaction

The Lab's unit of analysis is not the device or the model. It is the interaction between a technology and the human system it enters. That interaction is where behaviour actually happens, and where a technology's real effects, intended and unintended, are produced.

The artefact is one layer

Around any technology sit users with habits, institutions with rules, infrastructures it depends on, and a place with its own economics. Change the technology alone and little may happen. Change how these layers relate to it, and everything can.

Effects emerge from the whole

A payment system's effect is not in the software; it is in how the software meets a person's cash-flow, a shopkeeper's trust, a regulator's rules. The effect is a property of the system, not the artefact.

WHY THE HUMAN SIDE COMES FIRST

A socio-technical question is a human question

Most evaluation of technology starts from the technology: does it work, is it accurate, is it efficient? The Lab starts from the people, because a socio-technical question is a human question first, and the technical facts only become meaningful once you know what they mean for someone.

Technical performance is necessary but not sufficient.

A diagnostic model can be accurate and fail in a clinic. A solar system can function perfectly and go unadopted. A monitoring tool can be precise and be distrusted into irrelevance. Technical success is the floor, not the ceiling.

The decisive questions are about people.

Whether a technology is affordable in a real household's economics, whether it is trusted, whether it fits existing habits, whether it reaches the marginalised or only the already-served: these decide outcomes, and none is a technical question.

KEY POINT**The ordering matters**

Social science first, technical literacy alongside. This is not a slogan; it is a method. Starting from the technology tempts you to measure what is easy and assume what is hard. Starting from the people forces you to find out what actually changed, then trace it back to the technology that produced it.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Recurring dynamics in a transition

Across sectors, the same patterns recur. Knowing them tells a researcher where to look and a decision-maker what to worry about.

The incumbent regime.

Every new technology enters a world already run by an old one. How it relates to that incumbent, routing around, competing, or depending on it, shapes its whole trajectory. (The Lab's BRW framework treats this in depth.)

The enabling layer.

Technologies rarely succeed alone. A vehicle needs charging and financing; a payment tool needs trust and agents. The enabling layer, often financial or institutional, frequently does more of the work than the technology itself.

The distribution of benefit.

A transition never reaches everyone at once. Who it reaches first, and who last or never, determines whether it is fair. "Who is left out?" is often the most important finding a study produces.

The measurement-to-action gap.

Producing evidence is not the same as changing a decision. A finding no one acts on, or a figure no one trusts, is a silent failure. The last mile, from measurement to action, is a transition in its own right.

FROM READING TO EVIDENCE

Turning a socio-technical reading into a study

A socio-technical reading is not an end in itself. Its purpose is to direct evidence-gathering, to turn a vague question into a precise one that fieldwork can answer.

The reading frames the question

Understanding the system tells you which obstacles to look for, which actors to interview, and which distributional questions matter. It converts "does this work?" into "is this reaching the people it was meant to, and if not, where does it break down?"

Fieldwork answers it

Interviews reach the reasoning beneath behaviour. Surveys establish breadth. Baseline-to-endline establishes real change. Read across reach, depth, and experience, they turn the reading into defensible evidence.

KEY POINT

The purpose of the whole exercise

The Lab provides the evidence; the people it works with make the decision. Done well, the two together bend a transition toward the humans inside it. That is what reading a transition is for.

ABOUT TRANSITIONS LAB

An independent research team

Transitions Lab studies how technologies meet real people, and turns what it finds into evidence that innovators and institutions can act on. It works in two modes that share one method: it publishes its own research openly, and it works under contract for others, holding both to the same standard.

Three commitments define the work. It is independent of the things it measures, which is the entire source of its evidence's value. It is social and technical at once, starting from the people and bringing genuine technical understanding alongside. And it reports honestly, including the inconvenient finding, because that is the reason to ask an outside research organisation rather than one's own instruments.

A good way of reading the world is more useful in the world than in a drawer.

READING A TRANSITION

WORKING WITH TRANSITIONS LAB

From reading to evidence

This primer sets out how the Lab reads a transition. Turning that reading into evidence that can guide a decision is what an engagement adds.

IN THIS FREE RESOURCE	IN AN ENGAGEMENT, WE GO FURTHER
The socio-technical lens and the dynamics to look for.	› A structured diagnosis of your specific system, its actors, barriers, and distributional questions.
The principle that the human side comes first.	› Fieldwork that reaches the people involved, in their language and context, not a desk review.
The recurring patterns, described.	› Which patterns are actually present in your case, tested against primary evidence.
The framework, as an idea.	› The framework applied, with the Lab's cross-sector evidence base behind the reading.

The primer is a way of seeing; an engagement is where it is turned on your case and carried into evidence.

If a decision in your work turns on evidence of what a technology or programme actually does to real people, we are glad to talk it through, with no obligation. transitionslab.org

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